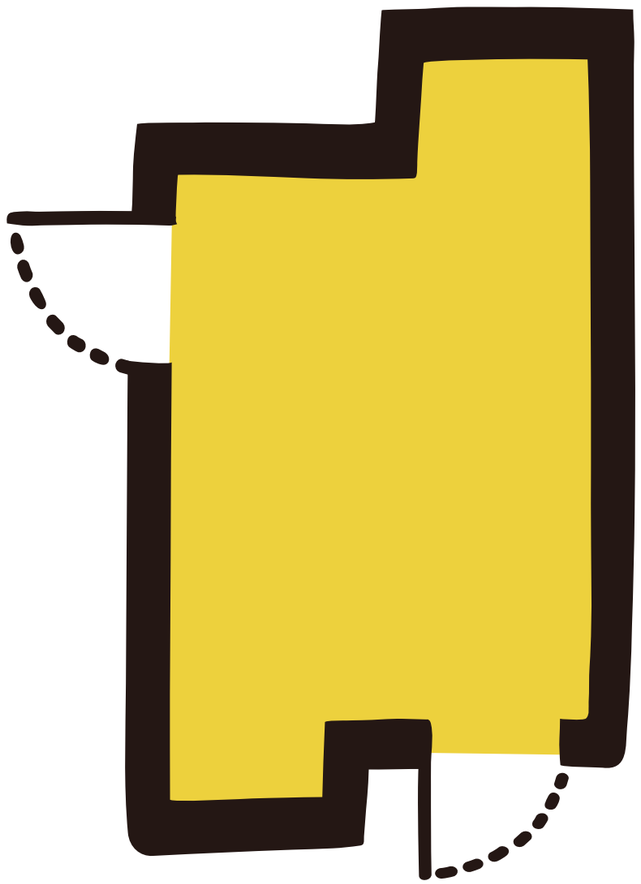
I Build A Museum For My Grandmother

Craft, Hybirdity, and Unresolved History in Taiwan



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Abstract

This practice-based thesis investigated how history, power, and identity are embodied and transmitted through everyday objects in Taiwan. Focusing on the historical experiences of Japanese colonial rule and subsequent authoritarian governance under the Kuomintang (KMT), the research examined how political ideologies became embedded in ordinary cultural forms such as folk tales, language policies, and product labels.

The project introduced the concept of Hybridity Objects to describe everyday objects that carry layered meanings shaped by colonialism, nationalism, and lived experience. Through ceramic reinterpretations of familiar forms — including origami crane, peaches, language plaques, and product labels — the work explored how historical forces become internalized through repetition and daily use. Rather than functioning as historical representations, these objects operated as material sites where memory and meaning were continually reactivated through the process of making.

Drawing on Hans-Georg Gadamer's concept of *Fusion of Horizons*, the thesis positioned craft as a method of historical engagement. The act of making became a site where inherited memories, particularly those connected to the artist's grandmother, intersected with the artist's present perspective. Understanding emerged through the encounter between different temporal horizons rather than through reconstructing the past. The research suggested that craft can offer a material way of engaging with unresolved histories and hybrid identities while keeping them open to reinterpretation.

Keywords:

Taiwanese identity, Taiwanese history, Postcolonial memory, Hybridity, Craft as research, Ceramic practice, Realm of memory, Fusion of horizons

Table of contents

01 **Introduction**

03 **Background**

05 **Me and My Grandma**

09 **Grandma's Love**

12 **The day of 1945**

15 **Hybridity Objects** - Origami Crane

19 - Gentle Peaches

21 - Labels of Made in….

22 - National Language Family

24 **Fusion of Horizons**

25 **Conclusion**

26 **Bibliography**

28 **Images**

29 **Appendix**

Introduction

My grandmother was born in 1925, during the Taisho period[1] of Japanese colonial rule in Taiwan. In her life, she lived through three political regimes: the Japanese Empire, the Kuomintang Chinese Nationalist[2] government, and later, democratic Taiwan. With regime change, language, identity, and historical narratives were rewritten. The official national language, Japanese, was replaced by Mandarin Chinese; local mother tongues were repeatedly suppressed. Their national identities were not chosen, but assigned. Her generation moved, often passively, through identities scripted by political authority—from Formosan, to Chinese, and only much later, to Taiwanese.

Her life was shaped by historical forces she neither chose nor controlled. And yet, the lived experiences of her generation remain largely invisible from official historical narratives. Each regime produced its own version of Taiwan's history, but rarely told how the ordinary people's everyday life was under the history that the authorities made. What remains overlooked are not grand events, but the quiet persistence of memory embedded in gestures, objects, and routines.

My project begins from that absence.

I build a museum for my grandmother—a fragile, temporary, material museum built through ceramic gestures, not as an institutional structure, but as a material practice. Rather than reconstructing history through archives or authoritative narratives, I approach history through craft and material re-making. Ceramic practice here functions as a mode of inquiry. Through finding and creating objects with culturally hybrid meaning, I engage with history as something fragmented, tactile, and lived.

1 Taisho (大正) is a period in the history of Japan dating from July 30, 1912 to December 25, 1926, coinciding with the reign of Emperor Taisho.
2 Kuomintang Chinese Nationalist is a major political party in the Republic of China (Taiwan). It was the sole ruling party of the country during its rule from 1927 to 1949 in Mainland China until its relocation to Taiwan, and in Taiwan ruled under martial law until 1987.

In this project, ceramics operate as a form of thinking. Techniques such as coiling[3] and slabbing[4] mirror the slow sedimentation of memory across generations. The objects I make are not replicas of historical artifacts. They are hybridity objects that are shaped by overlapping cultural, political, and personal histories. By translating everyday practices into ceramic form, I also build a bridge to a conversation with my grandma's generation, and I finally hear the voice that often excludes marginal voices from the majority narrative.

The museum I build for my grandmother does not speak with the voice of the state, nor does it claim completed the history. Instead, it offers a space where fragmented memories can remain unresolved and visible. In this space, objects function as sites of memory, the places where personal experience, colonial history, and contemporary reflection intersect.

Through this practice, I seek to activate a dialogue between generations. By remaking objects connected to my grandmother's life, I attempt to bridge what Hans-Georg Gadamer[5] describes as a fusion of horizons: an encounter between her historical position and my present perspective. Meaning does not emerge from restoring what was lost, but from acknowledging distance, rupture, and transformation.

These ceramic objects are traces of her existence. They ask:

Who holds the right to narrate history?
Whose memories are preserved, and whose are rendered invisible?
And how might craft function as a site where suppressed histories can be felt, rather than explained?

3 Coiling is a ceramic hand-building technique in which clay coils are stacked and joined to form a shape.
4 Slabbing is a ceramic hand-building technique that uses flat clay sheets assembled to create forms.
5 Hans-Georg Gadamer was a German philosopher known for philosophical hermeneutics and the concept of fusion of horizons.

Background

I grew up in a family that did not migrate to Taiwan with the Kuomintang (KMT) government between 1945–1949. We called ourselves Taiwanren [6] or Benshengren [7] . As a child, I spent much of my time with my grandma, who was born in Taiwan under Japanese colonial rule. I literally experienced Japanese culture from my grandparents' generation, while learning the Chinese national narratives from textbooks used in elementary and middle school. It wasn't until I attended high school in 1997, during Taiwan's democratization, that I began to explore and reflect on my own identity.

In 2011, I moved to Sweden to study international relations and political science at Södra Vätterbygdens folkhögskola in Jönköping, Sweden. At the time, I hoped to continue further studies in this field. However, I gradually realized that the emotional weight of political discourse was difficult for me to carry. One particular moment remains vivid. During a class discussion, a teacher explained that Taiwan is not considered a country because statehood depends on recognition by other nations. According to this logic, if China does not recognize Taiwan, then Taiwan "cannot" exist as a country.

I was shocked. The statement felt like a denial of my very existence, spoken in front of my classmates, two of whom were Chinese. If Taiwan isn't a country, then does the group of people who identify as Taiwanese even exist? Taiwanese identity has been shaped by a long and layered colonial history—Spanish, Dutch, Japanese, and Chinese. The people here are not simply Chinese immigrants; there are also various Austronesian indigenous groups [8] , and others. If that group doesn't exist, can I still say I am Taiwanese? This frustrating experience left me with a lasting question, not just about my own identity or Taiwan's political status, but about the arbitrary and often invisible systems by which nations are recognized or erased on the global stage.

In 2022, I returned to Sweden to pursue my studies in ceramic art at Capellagården [9] on Öland. I was gradually inspired by Pop-art sculptor Claes Oldenburg's sculptures of everyday objects, and I began transforming familiar items into ceramic forms capable of carrying personal and cultural narratives. An instant noodle package or a can of preserved fruit became vessels for fragmented memories and represented my identity.

6 Taiwanren (臺灣人) meaning Taiwanese.
7 Benshengren (本省人) meaning local provincials.
8 Austronesian indigenous groups are Indigenous peoples whose cultures and languages belong to the Austronesian family, spread across Taiwan, the Pacific, and Southeast Asia.
9 Capellagården is a craft school in Sweden founded by Carl Malmsten, known for its emphasis on material-based learning and craftsmanship.

During this period, I also began making ceramic portraits of a young girl using the coiling technique. While working on them, each clay coil felt like a thread connecting me to moments from my childhood with my grandmother. One layer after another, the process gathered fragments of my identity and memories. It became a way to heal and to have a quiet conversation with myself about who I am. This process also brought back reflections on my childhood and made me think more deeply about my grandmother's past. She had lived through both the Japanese colonial period and the 38 years of martial law [10] by Kuomintang (KMT) in Taiwan. Her life experiences made me reconsider how Taiwan's colonial history has shaped my sense of self, both then and now.

This journey across places and through personal change has helped me understand Taiwanese identity as something constantly being shaped and reshaped. It often feels like I am moving through a space where being seen and not being seen are closely connected. There is always a quiet balance between resistance and compromise, which becomes a way of surviving.



Image 1: Biggest Little Things - Wei Lih Instant noodle



Image 2: Childhood Revisited No.3

10 Martial law in Taiwan refers to the periods in the history of Taiwan after World War II, during control by the Republic of China Armed Forces of the Kuomintang-led regime. The term is specifically used to refer to the over 38-year-long consecutive martial law period between 20 May 1949 and 14 July 1987. Richard C. Kagan (1982) Martial law in Taiwan, Bulletin of Concerned Asian Scholars, 14:3, 48-54, DOI: 10.1080/14672715.1982.10412657

Me and My Grandma

The period of Japanese colonial rule over Taiwan, in which my grandmother was born, had a direct influence on the Kokugo undo (national language movement)[11] and broader Kominka movement (Japanization policies)[12]. Her early education was conducted in Japanese, and she grew up navigating a life deeply influenced by the customs, language, and beliefs imposed through colonial governance. These assimilationist efforts were not confined to political structures; they permeated the intimate spaces of domestic and cultural life.

As a child, I often sat with my grandmother playing Otedama, a traditional Japanese beanbag game, singing with soft, melodic Japanese nursery rhymes. The beanbag she gave for me wasn't store-bought; it was hand-stitched from leftover fabric and filled with uncooked rice. Each piece of cloth was sewn together into something simple yet full of care.

One of the most memorable songs from my childhood was "*Momotaro*" (The Peach Boy). It tells the story of a boy who emerges from a giant peach, grows up, and sets off to Oni Island to defeat the monsters. Along the way, he gains the help of a white dog, a monkey, and a pheasant. Together, they overcome the monsters.

I saw it as a simple heroic tale. I remember being more curious about how big the peach must have been for a boy to fit inside than thinking about the meaning of the story. Even now, it's hard to believe that the melody of "*Momotaro*" still lingers in my memory, though only the tune remains, without the lyrics. This half-remembered song leaves me with a strange feeling, as if I'm caught in a liminal space between familiarity and estrangement.

Grandma practiced Japanese Buddhism, distinct from the Taoist traditions followed by the rest of our family. During ceremonies involving the burning of joss paper,[13] she would ask me for help, and I assisted her, participating in a quiet act of religious difference. Her fondness for Sashimi (raw fish) and spicy Wasabi, also the preparation of Onigiri (rice ball) for my school lunches, became subtle reminders of a colonial past that never fully left her.

11 Kokugo Undo (National Language Movement) was a Japanese government effort during the colonial period to promote the Japanese language and culture, aiming to assimilate colonized populations.
12 Kominka Movement was a Japanese colonial policy to transform colonized people into imperial subjects by promoting Japanese language, culture, and loyalty to the emperor.
13 Joss paper is coarse, often yellow paper made to resemble money, burned as an offering to ancestors or deities in Taoist rituals

I experienced these gestures as both natural and confusing. Although my grandmother identified herself as Taiwanese, the cultural fabric of her life was woven with Japanese threads. This contradiction embodies what postcolonial theorist Homi Bhabha (1994, p. 4) describes as "there is a space in-between the designations of identity," and that "this interstitial passage between fixed identifications opens up the possibility of a cultural hybridity that entertains difference without an assumed or imposed hierarchy".

Especially when viewed through a postcolonial lens, even the story of Momotaro takes on new meaning. What once seemed like innocent storytelling reveals itself as a cultural tool for political propaganda. As historian John Dower points out, Momotaro came to represent Japan's imperial destiny, with his animal companions symbolizing other Asian nations absorbed into the Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity Sphere (Dower, 1986, pp. 250–258).

What I once saw as a warm memory is also evidence of how Japanese culture deeply shaped Taiwan, often through subtle, persuasive means. The story subtly reflects colonial dynamics, where the colonizer is framed as a "civilizing" force imposing order on the 'wild' others, like the animals that follow Momotaro.

Under Japanese rule, Taiwan's Indigenous populations were categorized according to their perceived degree of assimilation. Those who adapted to Han or Japanese cultural norms were labeled shufan (cooked/civilized), while those who resisted assimilation were shengfan (raw/uncivilized). This binary classification reflected the colonial desire to govern through cultural domestication.

In 1945 (Showa peroid)[14], when my grandmother was 20 years old. After World War II ended, Taiwan was taken by Kuomintang (KMT) government, which lost the Chinese civil war with Communist Party in mainland China, marking the beginning of another form of colonization. My grandmother, like many others, was forced to learn a new national language: Mandarin Chinese. Street and school names were changed, and speaking Japanese or Taiwanese was forbidden in public. People were gradually losing their ability to speak their own languages. The history she had grown up with was suddenly erased or rewritten.

14 Showa period refers to the era of Emperor Hirohito's reign in Japan (1926–1989), marked by war, postwar recovery, and rapid economic growth.

The Kuomintang government launched the “Chinese Cultural Renaissance Movement [15] ” in the 1960s, intending to preserve "authentic" Chinese culture in contrast to the Communist Revolution in mainland China. But for many Taiwanese, especially those like my grandmother, this movement suppressed a plural cultural identity. It wasn’t just about becoming Chinese—it was about becoming the right kind of Chinese, one that fit the KMT’s national narrative. Her Japanese education became something to hide, and didn't fit the grand narrative.

As I grew older, I began to reflect on the cryptic phrases my grandparents often repeated. One that stayed with me was, “Children have ears but no mouths.” At the time, I didn’t fully understand its weight. It meant that I had to keep family conversations private. Speaking out could bring trouble, or worse, cause someone to vanish without a trace. That kind of fear was deeply rooted in my grandparents’ generation and revealed the lasting shadow of life under the White Terror Period [16] (1949-1991).

I think about that often, how she carried the memory of two colonizations, the Japanese rule, which tried to make her into a loyal subject of the empire, and the KMT rule, which tried to erase that history and overwrite it with Chinese nationalism. Both systems denied her the right to define herself. Or maybe for her, there was just one colonization?

Looking back now, I see that my grandmother’s continued attachment to certain languages and rituals was not merely a lingering childhood habit, but an act of protection. These were quiet forms of resistance against the authoritarian regime that attempted to erase personal and collective histories, such as she still identified herself as Taiwanese under Japanese rule, but the Kuomintang was simplifying, replacing them with a singular, state-sanctioned Chinese identity.

15 Chinese Cultural Renaissance Movement was a campaign to promote traditional Chinese culture and values in Taiwan as a way to strengthen national identity and counteract communist influence.
16 White Terror Period (1949-1991) was a time of political suppression in Taiwan, marked by martial law and persecution of dissent under KMT rule.

In my opinion, the history and her experience were a tragedy of the time, that no one ever asked the groups who they truly were. The local provincials (Taiwanren/Benshengren) and Aborigines (Yuanzhumin) [17] were never given the space to define themselves, only forced to become someone else. As political scientist and historian Benedict Anderson describes, an “imagined community”—a nation not based on actual interaction, but on shared narratives constructed by those in power. Anderson writes, “communities are to be distinguished, not by their falsity/genuineness, but by the style in which they are imagined” (Anderson, 1983, p. 6). In this sense, identity is not necessarily chosen, but shaped by the stories told about a people.

Taiwanese people were imagined as part of a broader “Chinese nation,” a community that existed more in narrative than in lived reality. Through education, propaganda, language policy, and censorship, the KMT sought to overwrite Taiwan’s complex colonial past and embed it within the mythos of a unified China. In this framework, Taiwanese were not asked to “become” Chinese, they were told they “already were”, erasing the multiplicity of local identities in favor of a homogenous nationalist vision.

This top-down imagination of community is precisely what Anderson critiques. The imagined nation, while powerful, often functions to exclude or suppress alternative histories and lived experiences. In Taiwan’s case, it meant that individuals like my grandmother were caught between the remains of Japanese colonial influence and the imposed identity of a “Chinese” citizen, never fully belonging to either. Their lives were continuously reshaped by external imaginations, rather than by their own voices.

17 Aborigines (Yuanzhumin) in Taiwan refers to the Indigenous peoples of Taiwan, who are ethnically Austronesian and have lived on the island long before Han Chinese settlement.

Grandma's Love

The objects and customs my grandmother left behind quietly carry the memories of Japanese colonial rule. In her hands, they were no longer abstract representations of imperial power, but a natural part of our family life. She preserved these memories silently, not through words, but through gestures. For me, these customs became small rituals, symbols of a belief that certain parts of life could still be trusted and held onto.

As her granddaughter, I did not inherit her nostalgia for Japan. I visited Japan for the first time in 2007, but I could not find her there. The Japan I encountered was not the one she had passed on to me. What became clear is that what she gave me was never Japan in any original or pure form.

As Indian English postcolonial theorist Homi Bhabha writes, the colonial legacy "is always ambivalent, split between its appearance as original and authoritative and its articulation as repetition and difference" (Bhabha 107). What my grandmother preserved was not an unaltered inheritance. It was something in between, altered, reassembled, and re-signified through the practices of daily life. Her version of Japan was shaped by colonial education, domestic labor, and emotional survival.

These cultural remnants all became affective objects. Through intergenerational intimacy, their meaning shifted. They were no longer signs of subjugation. They became irreplaceable ties to memory, care, and belonging. My grandma's love did not arrive as ideology; it arrived sewn into the small bags of rice she made with leftover fabric, and in the silence we shared while watching Japanese cartoons.

We always watched the Japanese versions with Chinese subtitles, Doraemon[18], My Neighbor Totoro[19], Kiki's Delivery Service[20], and others—because grandma spoke only Japanese and Taiwanese. As a child, I couldn't follow the subtitles, but understanding wasn't the point. What mattered was that we were together. Watching became our ritual—a quiet space where history, language, and love coexisted without needing translation. After she passed away, watching certain cartoons sometimes became a ritual of remembering the time I shared with her.

18 Doraemon is a Japanese manga and anime series, created by Fujiko F. Fujio, about a robotic cat from the future who helps a young boy with gadgets from his pocket.
19 My Neighbor Totoro is a 1988 animated film by Hayao Miyazaki, depicting childhood imagination and rural life in postwar Japan.
20 Kiki's Delivery Service is a 1989 animated film by Hayao Miyazaki about a young witch's journey toward independence and self-discovery.

As I understand, what she gave me was not Japan, but her version of it, stitched together from what she had been taught, what she endured, and how she chose to care. These fragments, neither fully colonial nor entirely decolonial is live on in me, not as fixed cultural symbols, but as evidence of how love can transform legacies, and how identity is built from what we are given, what we remember, and what we choose to carry forward.

Through my grandma's rituals, nursery rhymes sung in a colonial tongue, Japanese Buddhist practices distinct from dominant traditions, and the simple act of packing onigiri, I began to sense the entanglement of identity and history in Taiwan. Her life, shaped by Japanese imperialism and later constrained by Chinese authoritarianism, was lived in the margins of imposed narratives. And yet, it is precisely in these margins that the texture of Taiwanese identity emerges: not fixed, but fragmented; not pure, but hybrid. Something is continually in an ongoing negotiation of meaning, memory, and identity.

On this multi-layered postcolonial island, each generation and ethnic group inherits a different understanding of identity. Like many who grew up in a benshengren/Taiwanese family, my early education told me that I was Chinese, following the Kuomintang's China-centered narrative. Later, through political and personal awakening, I came to identify as Taiwanese. At the same time, I absorbed elements of Japanese colonial culture through my grandmother. In this sense, both she and I embody an ironic form of mimicry across generations.

The culture I inherited was not directly experienced by me, but re-performed, translated, and hybridized through daily life. The cultural remnants left by colonizers occupy an ambiguous space in the lives of the formerly colonized. These objects—songs, foods, languages, religious practices, and even simple games — are not neutral artifacts. They carry the weight of history, the force of assimilation, and the subtle but persistent imposition of colonial ideology.

Over time, however, these imposed elements are reinterpreted and woven into the intimate fabric of everyday life. For those who lived under colonial rule, such objects and practices often oscillate between pain and familiarity, resistance and belonging. They are traces of subjugation, but also materials through which new, hybrid identities are formed.

The Japanese nursery rhymes sung by my grandmother, and the onigiri she packed for my lunches, were not simply relics of colonial imposition. They became sites of personal meaning, family bonding, and cultural continuity. Through these practices, the past was not only remembered, but lived and transformed into something in-between.

As Homi Bhabha argues, colonial legacy is not a static inheritance but a “third space” in which meaning is constantly negotiated. The objects left behind by colonizers can be transformed into tools of agency, memory, and reinterpretation. In this sense, colonial artifacts and cultural practices are neither wholly oppressive nor entirely empowering. They exist as unstable symbols, haunted by their origins yet capable of being reclaimed and reimagined by those who inherit them.

Amid this hybridity and uncertainty, I felt the need to return to my grandmother’s historical moment. This desire emerged only after her passing, carrying with it a sense of belatedness—the realization that understanding often begins after what we seek to understand has already been lost. As her granddaughter, I attempt to approach the difficulties and pain of her time, not to reconstruct them fully, but to reflect on how these unresolved histories continue to shape the present in Taiwan.

This reflection leads me back to 1945, a watershed moment that forced identities, languages, and political allegiances to shift. As one colonial order collapsed and another was imposed, people lived through this transition suspended between uncertainty and adaptation. By tracing this historical threshold, I move from the intimate sphere of my grandmother’s daily rituals toward the broader structures—museums, official narratives, and educational systems—through which authorities have attempted to frame, simplify, or silence this complexity.

A Day in 1945

At the end of 2025, I traveled to Taiwan and Japan to research the events that unfolded during and after World War II in Taiwan. I visited the Showa Memorial Museum (Showakan)[21] and the Yushukan War Museum[22] in the Yasukuni Shrine[23] in Japan as well as the National Museum of Taiwan History and the National 228 Memorial Museum[24] in Taiwan. Moving between museums in both countries, I encountered a subtle yet striking continuity: the same historical moment, the day of Japan’s surrender, was narrated and materialized across different national contexts.

In the National Museum of Taiwan History in Tainan, a wall presents fragments of thought from people in Taiwan on the day the Japanese emperor announced Japan’s surrender. These testimonies reveal not a unified response, but a fractured emotional landscape. Some could not believe that Japan would be defeated, while others felt that Japanese rule had been too strict and wondered whether the arrival of the Chinese might bring relief.

“I was very happy knowing that I didn't need to hide in air-raid shelters anymore.”

“I was thinking, so this means everyone is going to die! I was shocked that I would become Chinese in about five days.”

“When we heard of Japan’s unconditional surrender, everyone was crying, forgetting that they were actually not Japanese.”

“One or two days before the surrender was announced, the Japanese asked us Taiwanese to listen to radio broadcasts from mainland China. But I had spoken Japanese ever since I was a child and couldn’t really understand Taiwanese Hokkien, so I didn’t know what the broadcasts were talking about.”

21 Showa Memorial Museum (昭和館) is a museum in Japan dedicated to preserving artifacts and history from the Showa era (1926–1989).
22 Yushukan War Museum (遊就館) is a Japanese museum located at Yasukuni Shrine, showcasing Japan’s military history and wartime artifacts.
23 Yasukuni Shrine (靖國神社) is a Shinto shrine in Tokyo that commemorates Japan’s war dead, including convicted war criminals, and remains politically controversial due to its connection to Japan’s wartime history.
24 National 228 Memorial Museum (二二八紀念館) commemorates the 1947 February 28 Incident, when a suppressed uprising led to many deaths and the start of Taiwan’s White Terror period.

These voices capture a moment when identity, language, and political belonging were suddenly destabilized. The end of the empire did not arrive with clarity, but as a confusion following the abrupt suspension of certainty.

At the Showakan in Tokyo, the same day is marked by another wall. Three Japanese newspaper front pages from August 15, 1945, are displayed alongside an old radio that plays the recorded broadcast of Emperor Hirohito's surrender speech. Standing before this display, I was reminded of another testimony from the wall in Taiwan:

"When I heard the broadcast on the radio at that time, the voice was buzzing and low, and the Emperor was speaking in an old-fashioned language that I didn't understand."

The same sound traveled across the empire, yet it was not equally intelligible to all who heard it. For some, it marked defeat; for others, displacement; for many in Taiwan, it marked the beginning of an unknown future.

In 1945, on the day Japan surrendered, no one could have known what would follow, my grandmother included. For those living in Taiwan at the time, the end of Japanese rule did not signal an end to uncertainty, but the beginning of another imposed order. My degree project centers on lives caught within this historical vortex, suspended between collapsing regimes and unforeseeable futures.

And what I search for in my practice is a certain kind of yearning, not nostalgia, but a reaching toward something I know I will never fully touch. Because my grandmother is no longer here, this yearning feels like holding onto something already fading, while continuing to move toward something that always remains just beyond the horizon.

No monument was ever built for them.

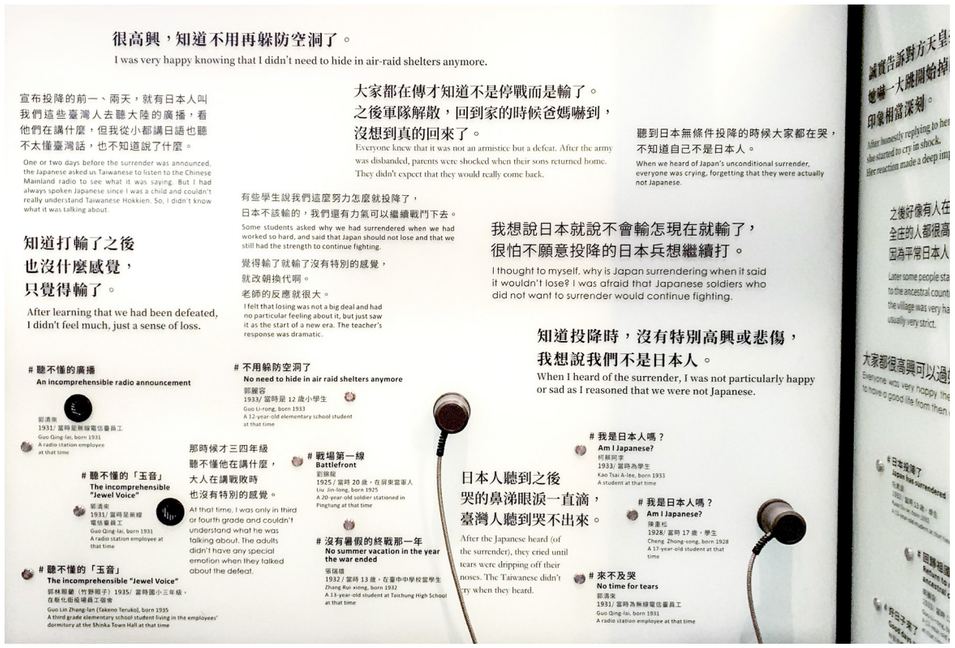


Image 3: Taiwanese during World War II (二戰下的臺灣人)

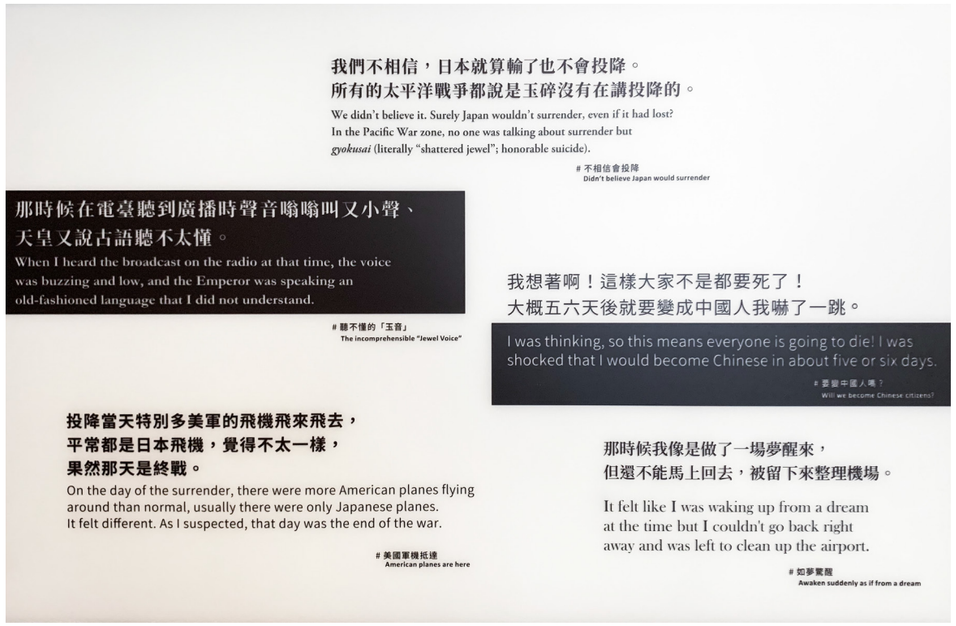


Image 4: Taiwanese during World War II (二戰下的臺灣人)

Hybridity Objects

1. Origami Crane

My interest as an artist and a researcher revolves around objects that are approached through craft—not as representations of history, but as material sites where memory is carried and transformed through making.

I began searching for objects that embody cultural hybridity, everyday practices so deeply absorbed that their origins become almost invisible. Origami was one such practice. As a child, folding paper was a common game, and I did not know that origami originated in Japan. For my generation of Taiwanese children, paper folding was part of daily life: folding paper cranes or stars as gestures of blessing and wish-making.

During the Mini Max course at Konstfack, I began experimenting with paper weaving as a craft-based method, which later extended to my use of newspapers. One particular newspaper entered my field of vision: a copy of the Daily Express published in the United Kingdom on August 15, 1945, the day Japan announced its surrender. Alongside the headline reporting Japan's surrender, a smaller article described the outbreak of the Chinese Civil War[25]. On a single front page, two events were reported that would go on to shape the lives of multiple generations in Taiwan. My method began by weaving this newspaper together with portraits of myself and my grandmother, visualizing how historical events and individual lives are entangled across generations.

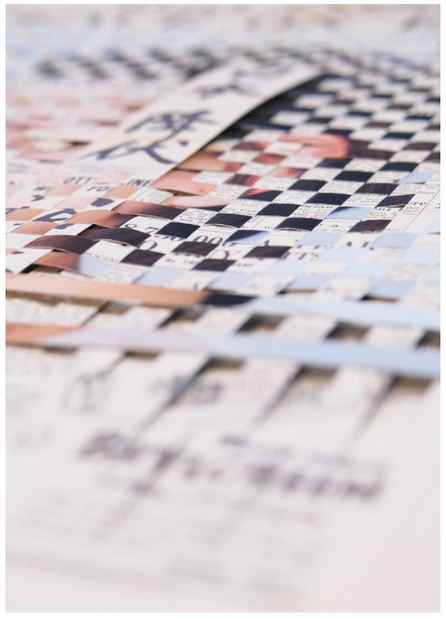


Image 5: paper weaving

Later, I returned to the same newspaper and translated it into ceramic form. The first piece I made was an origami crane[26], constructed using coiling and slab-building techniques. Inspired by Claes Oldenburg's oversized sculptures of everyday objects, I created a giant origami crane measuring 125 centimeters in width. By enlarging the scale and working in clay, the material resists the lightness typically associated with origami, transforming a fragile gesture into a burdened presence.

To ensure the structural survival of the crane through drying and firing, I developed a layered support system before shaping the form itself. Using newspaper, molochite[27], and a clay slab as the base, this method allowed the sculpture to shrink slowly and evenly together with the base, reducing tension at the joints. For the structurally fragile wings, I constructed additional clay pillars and positioned kiln shelves alongside them to prevent collapse during drying and firing. These preparatory actions required a level of time and care comparable to the making of the sculpture itself, embodying the spirit of craft-making as an integral part of the work's meaning.

Onto the surface of the crane, I painted texts from the newspaper: one article documenting Japan's surrender, the other reporting the outbreak of the Chinese Civil War. In paper, the crane can be folded, unfolded, and remade; its form remains open to repetition and correction. In ceramics, however, the moment is arrested. Once dried and fired, the object can no longer return to a state of becoming. This material irreversibility mirrors the historical rupture of 1945, which arrived as a condition that could not be reversed.

No monument was ever built for my grandmother's generation. Even the sculpture of the little girl at the exit of the Showakan Museum in Tokyo, which represents life during the Showa period, does not include the people who lived in Taiwan under Japanese colonial rule, despite Taiwan being part of the Japanese Empire at the time. Sites of memory often take concrete forms, such as monuments, museums, and archives. Yet the histories they present frequently privilege dominant groups, while marginal voices remain absent or obscured.

As French historian Pierre Nora reminds us, realm of memory (lieux de mémoire)[28] exist sprecisely because lived environments of memory have disappeared. The origami crane I created thus becomes a site of mourning—a craft-based lieu de mémoire for a bygone Taiwanese generation. As Nora writes: "There are lieux de mémoire, sites of memory, because there are no longer milieux de mémoire, real environments of memory" (Nora 1989, p. 7).

25 Chinese Civil War was a conflict (1927–1949) between the Nationalists (KMT) and Communists (CCP), ending with the CCP's victory and the establishment of the People's Republic of China.
26 Origami crane is a traditional Japanese paper figure symbolizing peace, hope, and healing.
27 Molochite is a type of calcined alumina. It contributes to greater dimensional stability, preventing cracking due to temperature changes.
28 Realm of Memory (Lieux de mémoire) refers to places, objects, or symbols where collective memory is preserved and transmitted, especially when living memory begins to fade. The term was developed by historian Pierre Nora.



DAILY EXPRESS

No. 14,101 — Lighting-up: 9.24 pm to 4.46 am — WEDNESDAY AUGUST 15 1945 — Weather: Thundery rain — One Penny

The full dramatic story of the last day of war

PEACE ON EARTH

Japan accepts Allied surrender terms : Attlee gives the news at midnight

160 WORDS IN CODE BRING THE REPLY

Two minutes to hand them over

JAPAN HAS ACCEPTED THE ALLIES' SURRENDER TERMS. THE WORLD IS AT PEACE. JAPAN'S "YES" WAS GIVEN IN A 160-WORD MESSAGE WHICH WAS PUBLISHED AT MIDNIGHT AND ANNOUNCED BY MR. ATTLEE IN A MIDNIGHT BROADCAST.

This was how the news arrived: at 8.5 last night the Jap Minister in Berne called at the Swiss Foreign Office. He stayed two minutes. As he left the U.S. Minister arrived. At 8.10 Japan's reply was handed to him.

He telephoned Japan's message to Washington. At 11.16 the reply was being considered at the White House by President Truman and Secretary of State James Byrnes.

The Japanese people had been told to stand by for the news of their country's surrender at mid-day, which is 4 a.m. British time.

While they waited, their Japanese cities, hit by 800 Super-Forts in 24 hours, still burned. And, as peace day dawned, the giant bombers were making the last raid of the war.

All the world waited for this—

MR. KASI'S CHAUFFEUR DRIVES THE BLACK CAR

From ERNEST ASHWICK

BERNE, Tuesday. — For two days crowds of people in this little Swiss capital have watched a big black car with a Japanese chauffeur waiting to take the Japanese Minister from his legation to the Swiss Foreign Office with the reply from Tokyo.

Tonight just after 8, Schunisch Kasi, the Minister, came out and the car drove off.

Hundreds of Berne citizens lined the streets to watch it speed along towards the Federal Government Palace.

During Mr. Kasi, flanked by his military attaché and first secretary and preceded by a Swiss flunkey in pale green uniform, walked down long red-carpeted corridors to see Foreign Minister Petitpierre for a frigidly polite interview.

End of dream

He handed over the document which puts an end for ever to the Japanese dream of a Greater Asia Empire.

Though the world waited, nothing could alter the slow, orderly pall of the flunkey.

Mr. Kasi looked pale. In a black suit, looking neither to left nor right, he walked through lines of newspapermen from every Victorious Allied nation.

Then he was alone, waiting for two days, sitting aloof, strolling and chain-smoking.

The Japanese reply began to come over at Geneva radio station at 6.45 p.m. It took two hours to receive, decode and check it for errors.

Early this morning there was a false alarm.

At 5.45 a.m. lights which had been burning all night in the Japanese Legation were put out. The Swiss Geneva radio began to hum.

The Japs began to put out a statement of 25,000 words which was not completed until mid-day.

Then came not the surrender accompanied

Atmospherics

Reception was bad, and Geneva radio station probably had to get on to Tokyo and have passages repeated.

These messages are not "broadcast" in the ordinary sense. They are beamed on a machine like a radio-typewriter.

They come out at the receiving end in the original language. Operators say atmospherics easily upset by atmospherics—especially over long distances.

When a message has been "jumped" for mutilation it is unreadable.

All this caused delay. And, of course, Tokyo sent its message in code.

And there it all the mystery of Tokyo was still unsolved.

Now at last tonight the waiting seems to be over.

China civil war warning

CHUNGKING, Tuesday. — The Chinese Communists, whose 18th Army Group controls 70,000 square miles of territory south of Mukden, have issued a warning to Russia for his orders denying them the right to take surrender from the Japanese troops they have been fighting.

"These orders," they say, are further proof of Chiang Kai-shek's preference for the Japanese to the Chinese people's democratic forces in his own country and of his active preparation for civil war.—A.F.

'Tears run unchecked in Sublime Palace grounds'

From C. V. R. THOMPSON: New York, Tuesday

AN apology from the Emperor Hirohito to millions of subjects he will soon lose, has been set up in type in newspaper offices throughout Occupied Asia since early this evening.

It was radioed from Tokyo by the Japanese News Agency with instructions: "Hold until permission to publish is announced." That permission has not yet been given.

The agency also began sending the newspapers this description of sorrowing Tokyo:—

"Tokyo, August 14, 1945.—The Imperial decision (regarding what, censored) was granted. The palace grounds are quiet beneath the dark clouds. Honoured with the Imperial edict, in the sublime palace grounds the mob of loyal people are bowed to the very ground in front of the Niju-Bashi (the bridge leading to the palace, and the nearest the public may go).

'FORGIVE US, EMPEROR'

"Their tears flow unchecked. Alas, in their shame how can the people raise their heads? How shall the hundred million people, filled with trepidation, reply to the Emperor?

"His Majesty's subjects are moved to tears by his Majesty's boundless and infinite solicitude. With the words: 'Forgive us, our Emperor, our efforts were not enough,' the heads bow lower and lower as the tears run unchecked.

"Ever since December 8, 1941, when we received the Imperial rescript causing his Majesty deep anxiety. "

There the story broke off. The Agency announced: "Editors, editors, hold that up."

Transmission was never resumed.

Later the agency began broadcasting this statement by Lieut.-General Reikichi Tada, urging the Japanese to abandon hopes of revenge, and to liquidate the military.

"The fact that the blood of our warriors was unable to set the world on a new path, can be seen in the Imperial message at this time as the revelation of God. I believe we should now divert all our efforts to the enhancement of culture through science."

Then editors were ordered to "kill" that.

MACARTHUR READY

After that, Tokyo's radio stood by. All musical programmes were abandoned. Most of the time there was silence.

And tonight the Japs are saying they have quit, Washington, with the rest of the world, still waits for them to make it official.

Once today there has been a terrific let-down. Berne said she had received the Jap reply to the Allies. Then she discovered she had not.

But tonight the Japs repeat that their official acceptance of the terms of Potsdam is on its way to Switzerland, and so to the Allies. We know now that is so.

And Washington is confident that the long vigil is nearly over.

General Douglas MacArthur is ready. The occupying forces which will land on Tokyo's shores are only a short steam away. Even the reporters are embarking upon the surrender boats, having drawn lots for the privilege of writing the first stories date-lined Tokyo since December 6, 1941.

This is it— 日本降伏

Japanese characters for— JAPAN (Nippon) SURRENDERS

A DOTTED LINE WAITS FOR— 裕仁

—The signature of Hirohito, Emperor of Japan. The top section means "Rich, generous, liberal, wise, wealthy." The lower, "Perfect virtue."

BRITAIN TO RUN JAPAN ISLAND

From NEWELL ROGERS

NEW YORK, Tuesday.—Britain may be invited by Washington to occupy one of Japan's four main islands.

America's War Department, Admiralty and Foreign Office are consulting for final approval by President Truman, the master plan for policing the enemy's homeland.

It proposes that the United States, Britain, Russia and China shall each occupy one island.

America would take over Honshu, larger than the three others put together, and seat of Tokyo.

Presumably the Russians would occupy Hokkaido, the northern island, since it adjoins Sakhalin and grants the approaches to Vladivostok.

TUNNEL LINK

Kyushu and Shikoku would be left for Britain and China. Of the two, Kyushu is most populous. Among its cities are Nagasaki, Birmingham of Japan, Yawata, Liverpool, Sasebo and Kagoshima.

Between Honshu and Kyushu is an undersea railway tunnel which speeded up Japan's war industries by 30 per cent. Allied engineer officers will take over on Honshu. One of their jobs will be to supervise the strengthening of the roadway of the Sakhaun, the bridal tunnel.

Their grip on Japanese wealth and power since the Middle Ages is everything possessed by the Presidents.

America also wants to move back to their homeland hundreds of thousands of Japanese who have robbed their sisters overseas.

'Republic talks'

PARIS, Tuesday.—Senor Miguel Maura, Spanish Republican leader, in Paris today, declared that the "restoration of the Republic in Spain was a Franco-Prussian Agency report today.—Reuter.

Control off

Restrictions on the release of copper for fully manufactured export goods were removed yesterday.

Germans celebrate Japan's defeat

From ALAN MOOREHEAD

MUNICH, Tuesday.—This is the end of the war, as we see it here in the centre of occupied Europe.

The Germans and Austrians are openly (and obviously sincerely) celebrating the defeat of their Ally.

A message from a German whom now working in a garage: "It shows how hopeless the war was from the beginning."

Another from a country village: "Now at last we can begin to get back to normal quicker."

In a captured German general's room they were enthusiastic over the Japanese defeat. "The Japanese broadcast the whole field of warfare," one said.

"The combination of our V weapons with an atomic warhead spells up immense possibilities. The scientists will now have to find a defensive against bombs."

American soldiers here appear to have three priorities about their future—first, go home; a close second, get a transfer to Europe; very last third, go to Japan.

Goering approves

Nuremberg, Tuesday.—Goering, the Far East, Fascists' commander-in-chief, is now in a cell occupying anywhere now we have the atomic bomb?"

Goering, Ribbentrop, Ley, Hitzelber, Joel, Keitel, Schacht, Von Papen and other leading Nazis who arrived at Nuremberg for the war criminals' trials yesterday seem to have survived their first night in the cells fairly enough—especially Goering.

They are reported to have heard of the end of Japan with fatalism and even with approval. Goering is said to have said that now everyone must bow to it.

For the rest, all these millions of people appear today to be accepting the peace more with a feeling of intense relief than an outburst of joy.

On the way down from Vienna I stopped at a wayside German eatery to eat my lunch beside the Steyr. The smith had got hold of a number of bits of steel and was busily making—I believe it or not, he was making ploughshares out of them.

ATTLEE HAD TO DRAW UP 2 SPEECHES

One with peace, one without

By GUY EDEN

EVEN the Cabinet was so uncertain last night of the exact position in the Far East war that Mr. Attlee was compelled to create a precedent by sending the King alternative drafts of the Speech to be read from the Throne at the State opening of Parliament this morning.

One—which the King will now use—expresses the "humble and solemn thanks" of the nation for the coming of peace. The other regretted that "the war continues."

The Government, in close consultation with the U.S., Soviet and Chinese Governments, had determined that there should be no official announcement of peace until it was clear that the Japanese had put themselves beyond any power to break it.

Today both Houses will go to special services at Westminster Abbey and St. Margaret's, West-

THE LAST BOMBS?

Korea is nearly cut off

Express Staff Reporter

GUAM, Wednesday. — Big fleets of Super-Forts have been over Japan since dawn in what may be the last raid of the war.

Their targets: aircraft plants and oil refineries on Honshu—Tokyo's island.

Japan claims suicide . . . planes on a carrier and striker of the Yokosuka Naval Base, and dive bombers of the . . .

News from other fronts :—

Marshal Malinovsky's troops, advancing more than 75 miles a day through Manchuria from the west, are barely 200 miles from the Yalu River, Korea's border, and are 100 miles from Hutkai.

Japan's communications with Korea have been practically cut by the Red Fleet.

Marshal Stalin, former the Japs are still fighting bitterly.

Belgian Regent here

Prince Charles, Regent of Belgium, visited Buckingham Palace yesterday and had lunch with the King and Queen.

Quite a drop

War expenditure showed a reduction of £18,250,000 last week.

2 a.m. LATEST

JAPAN—THE TERMS

Mr Attlee, broadcasting at midnight, said:—

Japan has today surrendered. Japanese rep., says ceremony is arranged to put into effect the decisions of the Potsdam Conference and order disarmament of Japanese forces.

Premier announced that today and tomorrow will everywhere be treated as days of holiday.

minster, when they have heard the Speech from the Throne and then return to pass a vote of congratulation.

The King and Queen plan to go to the House of Parliament next Tuesday to receive these congratulations personally, and the King will read the same speech in the presence of both Lords and Commons. In this he will thank the whole nation for the victory they have helped to win.

The decision earlier was: if peace had not been declared by the time the King opens

BACK PAGE, COL. SIX

£8,750,000 A YEAR TO BUY PITS

By TREVOR EVANS

A SOCIALIST committee in London next week will discuss a proposal which means buying out the mine-owners for about £8,750,000 a year.

The committee, composed of representatives of the Party Executive, the T.U.C. and the miners' union, will consider three alternatives for nationalisation :—

1 This a technical commission shall assess each mine and recommend a valuation for sale to the Government.

2 That a block grant be made to the industry to yield 31 per cent. on the estimated capital instead—calculated as between £200,000,000 and £250,000,000.

Plan No. 3 is made ready to be adapted for submission to the Government because, said a committee member last night, valuations of each colliery, though the cheaper way, would take too long. Under Plan No. 3 the owners will suffer an immediate and substantial cut in annual allowances, as well as the loss of their property.

£4,000,000 cut

For all the Coal Charges Order (Interim) 1945, which cuts £12,750,000 a year in average profit on production alone, apart from distribution profits, which will be cut by £4,000,000 more when this side of the Bill takes over this side of the industry.

All that would get from the Government is 3½ per cent. interest on £250,000,000—about £8,750,000.

The joint committee was set up three months ago to work out plans for nationalisation.

When it meets on Wednesday and Thursday next week it will be under the chairmanship of Mr. Will Lawther, president of the National Union of Mineworkers, who succeeded Mr. Emanuel Shinwell three weeks ago.

And the committee will report their recommendations to Mr. Shinwell, Minister of Fuel and Power, will consider them for the . . . he is prescribing in the . . .

Prisoners to speed home

SUPREME H.Q., S.E.A.C., Tuesday. — Some of the thousands of British and Empire troops held prisoner by the Japanese will return home as soon as our armies occupy Singapore and Malaya.

Only those too weak to travel will require further medical attention or mental rehabilitation will first be cared for in hospitals in India.

It is emphasised that the British Services will be kept busy for eight, nine and even ten months after the surrender, and that the evacuation of civilians into Japan's new home territory will absorb even more man-power than would be required during the initial stages of a planned invasion.

Early repatriation of British troops will be impossible. For some time there will be even more urgent demands on shipping.

Atomic bomb talks soon

WASHINGTON, Tuesday. — The first international conference on the atomic bomb will take place in Canada next month.

The countries taking part will be U.S., Britain and Russia and Canada. Discussions will deal with the industrial possibilities of the new energy source.—Exprss News Service.

Eisenhower sees a Soviet farm

MOSCOW, Tuesday.—General Eisenhower went sightseeing today. He visited a collective farm, 35 miles from Moscow, in a region where Marshal Zhukov worked as a farm boy.—A.P.

Please return

BRYLCREEM

bottles when empty

There is an acute shortage of bottles. So if you will return the empties to the shop where you get your Brylcreem it will help us to keep up supplies.

THANK YOU!

Cussons Proprietary Co., Ltd., 15-19, Stratford Place, London, W.1

Image 6: Daily Express Newspaper, August 15, 1945 — Headline announcing Japan's surrender, marking the end of World War II and the beginning of peace on earth, and the China civil war warning in the corner



Image 7: origami cran process photos



Image 8: layered support system of origami crane

2. Gentle Peaches

Momotaro is a Japanese folktale widely known in Taiwan. The story tells of a boy born from a giant peach who, after growing up, travels to an island of demons to defeat evil. Traces of this character were repeated throughout my childhood.

According to my father, during the dictatorship of Chiang Kai-shek[29] in Taiwan, schools distributed peach-shaped buns[30] to students each year to celebrate his birthday. In traditional Chinese culture, peaches symbolize longevity and auspiciousness, which strongly connect to the Chinese mythology, the Queen Mother of the West[31] cultivates peaches in her celestial garden—fruits that ripen only once every three thousand years and grant immortality to those who consume them.

Within these overlapping contexts, the peach becomes a carrier of layered cultural meanings. It can appear as an innocent children's story or a simple nursery rhyme, while simultaneously evoking the metaphor of Japanese imperial expansion embedded in the narrative of Momotaro. At the same time, it functions as a symbol of authoritarian power through the ritualized celebration of a dictator's birthday, and as a mythical object of eternal life within Chinese cosmology. In this transformation, the power does not appear in the form of violence or command, but is wrapped in soft, caring, and blessed cultural symbols. The peach allows authority to appear benevolent and culturally intimate.

In my practice of the peaches, I am interested in how the peach constructs an initial impression of harmlessness and blessing while enabling a display of authoritarian and colonial power through material strategies such as the surface finish. The surface creates a visual illusion of softness and tactility. However, when touched, the peaches reveal a coarse and rigid texture. I hope the viewer experiences this contradiction: something that appears to be made with care, yet is structured by control.

Through this tension between innocence and domination, the peach operates as a hybridity object—one shaped by colonialism, nationalism, and mythology—revealing how political power can become naturalized through everyday cultural forms and quietly absorbed without resistance.

29 Chiang Kai-shek was a Chinese political and military leader who led the Nationalist Party (KMT) and governed Taiwan after retreating from mainland China in 1949. He governed Taiwan from 1949 until his death in 1975.
30 Peach-shaped bun (壽桃) is a traditional Chinese steamed buns shaped like peach, symbolizing longevity and often served at birthday celebrations.
31 The Queen Mother of the West is a goddess in Chinese mythology associated with immortality, often depicted holding the peaches of eternal life.



Image 9: Sprayed bisque engobe process photos



Image 10: Testing firing of bisque engobe, and printed vinyl label

3. Labels of Made in….

Over the past century, Taiwan's export economy has shifted from agriculture to manufacturing and later to high-tech industries. During the period of Japanese colonial rule, Taiwan's primary export products were agricultural goods, particularly fruits such as pineapples and bananas. On canned food packaging from that era, the place of origin was labeled Made in Formosa, Japan. After the Kuomintang government retreated to Taiwan in 1945, the ideology of a "Greater China" was imposed on the island. Even though the Chinese mainland was already under the control of the Chinese Communist Party (PRC), the Kuomintang (KMT) continued to claim sovereignty over China. During this period, Taiwan became a major exporter of plastic and light industrial products to the global market. These goods were marked Made in Taiwan, ROC. As Taiwan gradually moved away from authoritarian rule and toward democratization, the designation ROC was slowly diluted, eventually disappearing from export labels. What remained was simply Made in Taiwan.

From Made in Formosa to Made in Taiwan, ROC, and finally to Made in Taiwan, these labels trace not only economic transformation but also shifting regimes of power and imagination. This progression reveals how the people living on this island have been repeatedly shifted within different national narratives constructed by successive rulers. Yet I argue that at no point did the population fully or uniformly identify with any single imagined community.

Through my practice, I designed a series of fruit labels referencing different historical moments. In doing so, I temporarily occupy the position of the one who defines origin, value, and belonging. On a smaller scale, this act mirrors the political authority that once used such labels to imagine and impose national identity. I then place the fruit labels onto the peaches. This act becomes a small gesture of authority: the peaches appear identical, yet I determine which label each one receives.

As a Hybridity Object, labels of Made in… reveal how national identity is manufactured through everyday commodities. It embodies the tension between economic realities and imposed narratives. For those living on the island, these labels have never resolved the question of belonging, but have instead layered it with ambiguity.

4. National Language Family

During Japanese colonial rule, some Taiwanese households displayed iron plates granted by the government to families with members who fought for Japan or lost a family member in the war. Among these was a plaque bearing four Japanese Kanji characters: National Language Family (國 語 家 庭). In this context, "national language" referred to Japanese, and such a plate signified a household fluent in Japanese and living according to Japanese customs.

After the Kuomintang government retreated to Taiwan in 1945, a strict language policy was enforced. People were required to abandon Japanese and local languages such as Taiwanese Hokkien, and to use Mandarin Chinese exclusively. Rather than dismantling the colonial language framework, the KMT inherited it, transferring the concept of national language (國　語) from Japanese to Mandarin Chinese. Ironically, the written characters remained the same, while the spoken language shifted entirely.

At the National 228 Memorial Museum, I watched a documentary highlighting the consequences of these policies. The abrupt linguistic shift caused widespread illiteracy among Taiwanese educated in Japanese, while intensifying ethnic tensions between local Taiwanese and mainland Chinese immigrants—factors contributing to the February 28 Incident and the subsequent execution of many Taiwanese.

The suppression of local mother tongues continued under this regime. Languages like Taiwanese, Hakka, and Austronesian tongues were labeled inferior, and speaking them was meant to get punished. Language became a tool of domination, shaping identity through enforced conformity.

In my practice, I translate the National Language Family iron plaque into ceramic form, mimicking the original iron plaque in a sculpture form: one bearing the text "National Language Family" alongside the Japanese Empire flag, the other side alongside the KMT flag. Both surfaces are intentionally treated with traces of corrosion and wear, evoking historical passage and the enduring weight of imposed identities. These plaques are conceived as reversible objects. Turning them over reflects the historical transition of linguistic authority—from Japanese to Mandarin—while revealing how the underlying structures of domination remain unchanged.

This concept also reveals the limits of institutional memory. While museums and archives claim to preserve history, they often privilege dominant languages and narratives. Within this system, the National Language Family plaque raises an unresolved question: did families accept it as an honor or as a protective shield under authoritarian rule? Over time, exposed to weather and neglect, the plaque accumulates corrosion, mirroring the erosion of certainty surrounding identity and belonging.

For me, Taiwanese became the language most deeply tied to my grandmother. It was the only language through which we could truly understand one another. Due to prolonged language policies, I am not fluent in Taiwanese. This reclamation is not driven by fluency but by necessity. Returning to Taiwanese in my practice resists enforced forgetting and allows history to be approached through intimacy and care rather than institutional narratives.



Image 11: Working process of national language family sculpture,
embossed Japanese text on the left and Traditional Chinese text on the right

Fusion of Horizons

Over time, I came to understand that the objects I make emerge through an active dialogue between inherited memory and my present position as a maker.

For many years, my artistic practice repeatedly returned to Taiwanese politics and the memories connected to my grandmother. At first, this return felt intuitive rather than clearly defined as research. It was only through sustained making, first at Capellagården and later at Konstfack, that I began to recognize this repetition not as nostalgia, but as a form of inquiry. I do not approach the past as something that can be recovered intact. My understanding of history is always shaped by my present position as a Taiwanese, my distance from my grandmother's lived experience, and the material processes through which I engage with it.

This realization can be articulated through the philosophy of Hans-Georg Gadamer and his concept of the Fusion of Horizons. For Gadamer, understanding does not occur through neutral reconstruction, but through an encounter between historically formed perspectives — the horizon of the past and that of the present. Interpretation is therefore not a return to original meaning, but an event shaped by distance, contingency, and situated experience.

Gadamer emphasizes that in the process of understanding, a real fusing of horizons occurs, which means that as the historical horizon is projected, it is simultaneously superseded. To bring about this fusion in a regulated way is the task of what we called historically effected consciousness. (Gadamer, 2013, p. 317)

Within my practice, this fusion takes material form through craft. Clay, glaze, scale, repetition, and firing do not merely shape objects; they shape meaning. Each act of remaking introduces friction between what once was and what can exist now. We do not retrieve the past from outside history; we encounter it from within positions already shaped by it.

This awareness that interpretation is historically conditioned becomes central to my way of working. In this sense, fusion of horizons in my practice is not only conceptual but embodied. It occurs through the physical engagement with material, where inherited memory and present perspective meet and transform one another.

Conclusion

This thesis has explored how history, power, and identity become embodied in everyday objects, and how craft can serve as a way of engaging with historical situations that cannot be fully commemorated or resolved. In my practice, history is not approached as a distant narrative but as something lived, inherited, and continually reactivated through encounters with materials and objects.

Through the concept of Hybridity Objects, I examined how colonialism and authoritarianism become embedded in ordinary cultural forms—origami, folk tales, language plaques, and product labels. These objects operate quietly within daily life, allowing ideology and power to be internalized through repetition and familiarity. By translating these forms into ceramics, my practice exposes their layered and often contradictory histories while emphasizing the material commitment of ceramics as a medium that holds and transforms memory.

The chapter on Fusion of Horizons articulated my position as a maker engaging with a past I did not fully live but continue to inherit. Drawing on Gadamer's hermeneutics, I understand my practice as an encounter between different horizons: my grandmother's lived experience under colonial and authoritarian regimes, and my own position shaped by distance and partial knowledge. Craft is not a neutral medium in this encounter, but the place where understanding becomes tangible. Through remaking, scaling, glazing, repetition, and firing, historical meanings are brought into the present without attempting to resolve their distance or contradictions.

In this sense, this research suggests that craft can function as a way of remaining with historical ambiguity. Rather than offering resolution, craft allows unresolved memories and identities to persist in material form and to be encountered again.

I do not have answers to the questions raised at the beginning of this thesis. Building a museum for my grandmother was never an attempt to correct history or to criticize it from a distance. Criticism places me outside history, while this project has shown me that I am already part of it. Building this museum has been a way of learning how to live with an inherited past — a way of recognizing that history is not something behind us, but something we continue to carry.

Through craft, I have come to understand that the objects I make do not only preserve memory. They also mark my own position within history, a position that remains unfinished, uncertain, and still in the process of becoming.

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Image

Image 1: Biggest Little Things - Wei Lih Instant noodle, Mu-Se Kuo, 2024

Image 2: Childhood Revisited No.3, Mu-Se Kuo, 2023

Image 3&4: Taiwanese during World War II (二戰下的臺灣人)
National Museum of Taiwan History, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Image 5: Paper weaving, Mu-Se Kuo, 2025

Image 6: Daily Express Newspaper, August 15, 1945,
John Frost Newspapers, Alamy Limited

Image 7: Origami cran process photos, Mu-Se Kuo, 2025

Image 8: Layered support system of origami crane, Mu-Se Kuo, 2025

Image 9: Sprayed bisque engobe process photos, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Image 10: Testing firing of bisque engobe, and printed vinyl label, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Image 11: Working process of national language family sculpture, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Image 12: Folded August 15, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Image 13: Momotaro's hacienda, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Image 14: Momotaro's hacienda, ceramic peaches with labels, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Image 15: Overview, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Image 16: National language family with Japanese characters, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Image 17: National language family with Traditional Chinese characters, Mu-Se Kuo, 2026

Appendix

After the examination and Spring Exhibition, I found myself understanding the project differently. Meanings that had felt intuitive during the making process only became visible afterward, through conversations with examiners, visitors, and unexpected encounters around the work.

One of the most important realizations was that meaning is never fixed within an object. Instead, it is continuously negotiated through context, display, misunderstanding, and encounter. Questions surrounding accessibility, interpretation, and authorship repeatedly surfaced and gradually shifted how I understand my practice.

One particularly unexpected moment emerged through visitors' interpretations of National Language Family, the rotating ceramic sculpture. Several Swedish visitors mistakenly identified the structure as resembling a milk carton. At first, this misunderstanding surprised me. The sculpture carried references to colonial language policies in Taiwan through Japanese and Chinese text, which felt visually direct to me. Yet for audiences unfamiliar with these symbols, the work operated entirely differently. Over time, I stopped seeing this misunderstanding as a failure of communication. Instead, it became an opportunity to reflect on cultural translation and the instability of symbols. Can an artwork ever be fully understood across every cultural context? Or can misunderstanding itself become a meaningful space of encounter? I still do not know where the balance lies between legibility and opacity, and perhaps that uncertainty itself has become part of the work.

Yet if Western visitors' misreadings provided a space for reflection, responses from some East Asian viewers revealed another layer of complexity. I sensed a different kind of hesitation when engaging with the work, particularly around the Japanese colonial references, perhaps because the project approaches colonial history through intimacy, contradiction, and everyday memory rather than a singular position of condemnation. This made me aware of how easily complexity can be misread, and how the work occasionally risks being interpreted as romanticizing colonial history. I also recognize that part of my discomfort came from a fear of being misunderstood. Taken together, these responses revealed that ambiguity does not function in the same way across all audiences: for some, it created an opening; for others, anxiety. That tension became one of the most important questions shaping my future practice.

Another unexpected realization came through visitors' behavior toward the white tape marking the museum boundary on the floor. Some carefully avoided stepping inside the marked area, while others asked whether they were allowed to enter, despite there being no physical barrier. What appeared to me as a simple spatial marker unexpectedly carried institutional authority. By outlining a boundary, I had created a behavioral system and unknowingly positioned myself in a role of authority. This led me back to a question that followed the project from the beginning: who holds the right to narrate history? Building a temporary museum, I realized, is not simply an act of care or preservation, but also one embedded in questions of authorship and authority.

This question also extended into the personal. During the research trip to Taiwan at the end of 2025, I visited the National Taiwan Museum in Taipei, originally established in 1908 during the Japanese colonial period. I don't know if my grandmother had visited the museum or not, but she brought me there during my own childhood. This layered experience complicated my relationship with museums. On one hand, museums can function as colonial institutions of classification and power; on the other, they can also become spaces of intimacy, learning, and intergenerational memory.

The exhibition also repeatedly raised questions about accessibility. Because the project is rooted in Taiwan's colonial and authoritarian histories, some visitors asked whether audiences unfamiliar with these contexts could fully engage with the work. In response, I introduced three postcards offering historical background for individual pieces, providing optional entry points rather than explanations. I also created museum tickets as an invitation for visitors to enter the temporary museum as participants rather than spectators. These decisions revealed an ongoing question within my practice: how much explanation is necessary, and when should ambiguity remain? Rather than simplifying complexity, I became increasingly interested in how exhibitions might create spaces that balance access with uncertainty.

Through these reflections, I found myself repeatedly returning to a question central to my artistic position: what might a postcolonial or decolonial practice mean within my own context? I no longer imagine decolonial practice as removing traces of colonial history. Instead, I see it as learning how to stay with contradiction—making space for overlooked memories, fragmented histories, and uncomfortable inheritances to remain visible. As someone shaped by Taiwanese colonial history through family memory while also living abroad, I often find myself occupying an uncertain position. Rather than resolving that ambiguity, I want to learn how to work with it honestly and with care.

Through this process, I have come to understand the degree project not as an endpoint, but as a beginning. Building a temporary museum for my grandmother shifted my attention from

craft as a method for approaching history toward investigating how exhibition-making itself can become a space for negotiating memory, absence, and marginalized narratives.

Moving forward, I hope to continue exploring exhibition-making as part of my artistic practice, not only through ceramic objects, but also through spaces, archives, and forms of mediation that allow histories to be encountered differently. I understand my role not as someone who explains history, but as someone who creates temporary conditions for it to be encountered: sometimes clearly, sometimes partially, and sometimes through misunderstanding. Rather than seeking fixed understandings, I want to continue making spaces where difficult histories can remain visible, shared, and open to conversation across generations and cultural contexts.

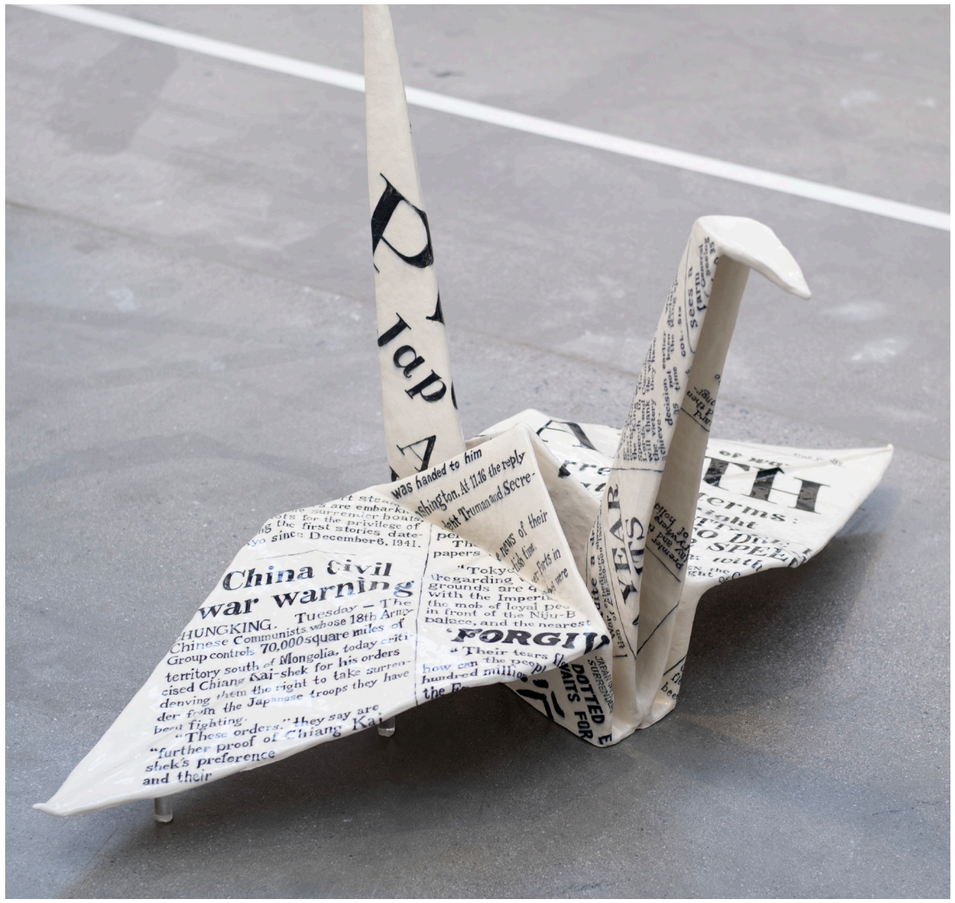


Image 12: Folded August 15



Image 13: Momotaro's hacienda



Image 14: Momotaro's hacienda, ceramic peaches with labels



Image 15: Overview



Image 16: National language family with Japanese characters



Image 17: National language family with Traditional Chinese characters